Coastal field guide

Shorebirds of the Derwent estuary · A pocket companion for volunteer surveyors

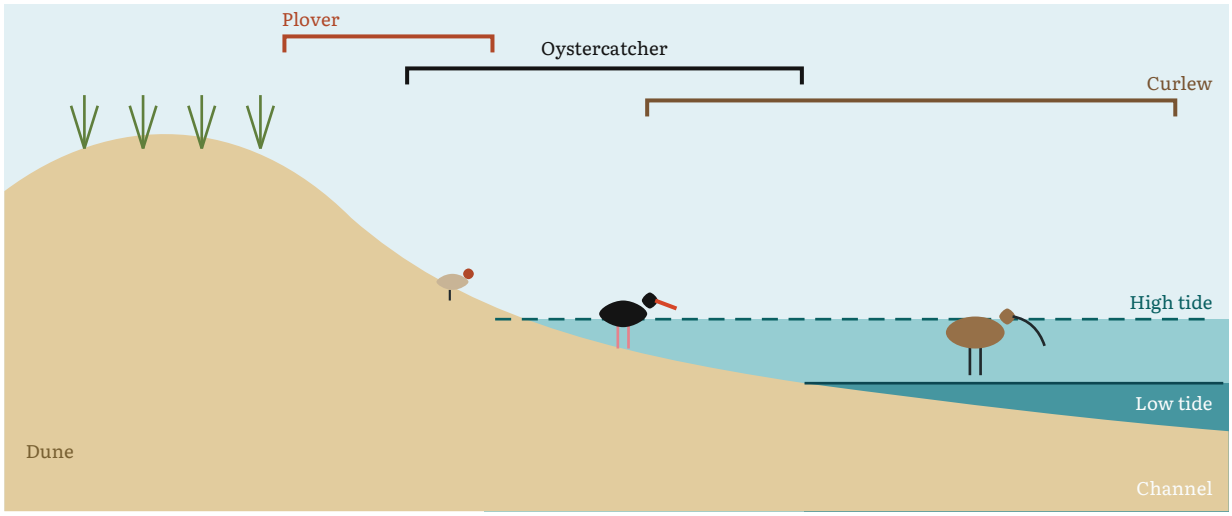

Figure 1. From dune to channel: where each species feeds

Reading the estuary

Shorebirds follow the tide. Most feed on the *falling* tide, when fresh mud is exposed, and roost above the high-tide line in the two hours either side of high water. Plan counts around the roost: birds are packed together and easy to tally. The three species described in Species accounts between them use every zone in Figure 1.

- **Dune and upper beach**: nesting plovers from August to January. Keep to the wet sand.
- **Sand flats**: oystercatchers probing for pipis and worms.
- **Soft mud and shallows**: curlews and godwits working the channel edge.

Roost counts from two hours before to one hour after high tide, when birds pack together above the tide line.

Feeding counts on the falling tide, three to five hours after high water.

Wind avoid days above 25 km/h; birds hunker down and are hard to see.

Before you go

- **Tide table**: the Hobart port times, plus about 20 minutes for the inner flats.
- **Optics**: 8 × 42 binoculars for the roost, and a telescope for the far channel edge.
- **Survey sheet**: the checklist in Survey checklist, printed on one page, and a pencil.
- **Clothing**: dull colours, a hat, and boots for the wet sand.

A count is called off when the Bureau of Meteorology issues a strong wind warning for the Derwent. The coordinator confirms every count in the group's channel by 7 am on the day.

Species accounts

Each plate below is drawn to the same scale, so relative size is a first clue. Compare bill shape next: it tells you how, and where, a bird feeds.

Figure 2. Plates to scale: pied oystercatcher, red-capped plover, and Far Eastern curlew

Pied oystercatcher

A bold black-and-white wader that feeds in pairs across the open flats. Its all-black cousin, the sooty oystercatcher, prefers rocky shores. Compare the curlew, which shares the flats but probes deeper.

- **Size:** 42 to 50 cm; the largest black-and-white bird on the flats.
- **Field marks:** long straight *orange-red* bill, red eye-ring, pink legs.
- **Call:** a loud, piping “kleep kleep” when disturbed.

Red-capped plover

A tiny, fast-running plover that nests in a bare scrape on the upper beach. Eggs and chicks are almost invisible against the sand, so follow the field etiquette closely during the nesting season.

- **Size:** 14 to 16 cm; smaller than a sparrow.
- **Field marks:** pale grey-brown above, white below; adult males have a *rufous* cap and a dark bar across the shoulder.
- **Call:** a thin, sharp “tik” as it runs ahead of you.

Far Eastern curlew

The world's largest shorebird, and an endangered migrant that flies from breeding grounds in Siberia each September. It is wary: record it from a distance and never approach a roost. Unlike the oystercatcher, it feeds alone.

- **Size:** 53 to 66 cm; the bill alone can reach 18 cm.
- **Field marks:** streaked brown all over, with a very long *down-curved* bill.
- **Call:** a mournful, rising “cur-lee” carried across the water.

Running a survey

Counts are held on the second Sunday of each month, starting one hour before high tide. Enter your results in the national database with the site code `DERW-04`, or send your sheet to the survey coordinator.

1. Note the time, the tide height, the weather, and any disturbance.
2. Scan the roost from one end to the other, counting in blocks of ten:
   - count the large species first,
   - then sweep again for the small ones.
3. Record colour-banded birds with the band colours, top to bottom, left leg first.
4. Enter a zero for every species you looked for and did not find.

Distance stay at least 50 m from roosting and nesting birds, and further from a curlew roost.

Dogs keep them on a lead; dogs are banned from the spit all year.

Alarm if birds take flight or call in alarm, you are too close.

Survey checklist

The species most often recorded on the estuary. Status follows the national threatened species list; see the Atlas of Living Australia for maps and records.

Table 1. Survey details

Observer		Date	
Start time		High tide	
Site code	`DERW-04`	Weather	

Table 2. Shorebirds recorded on the estuary, with a column for your count

Species	Scientific name	Season	Status	Count
Pied oystercatcher	*Haematopus longirostris*	All year	Resident	
Sooty oystercatcher	*Haematopus fuliginosus*	All year	Resident	
Red-capped plover	*Charadrius ruficapillus*	All year	Resident	
Hooded plover	*Thinornis cucullatus*	All year	**Vulnerable**	
Masked lapwing	*Vanellus miles*	All year	Resident	
Far Eastern curlew	*Numenius madagascariensis*	Sep to Apr	**Endangered**	
Bar-tailed godwit	*Limosa lapponica*	Sep to Apr	**Vulnerable**	
Red-necked stint	*Calidris ruficollis*	Sep to Apr	Migrant	
Double-banded plover	*Charadrius bicinctus*	Mar to Aug	Migrant	